Content Effects: Advertising and Marketing

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Abstract

The study of advertising effects usually follows two traditions. The first relates the intensity of advertising input (mostly ad expenditures and exposures) to behavioral and market outcomes (mostly sales and market share) using statistical modeling techniques to determine advertising effectiveness. The second seeks to uncover individuals' mental responses to advertising stimuli that are associated with memory, attitudinal, and behavioral effects of advertising. This entry describes the logic of research, central concepts and theories in these two traditions and outlines long-term trends in academic advertising research.

Advertising and the study of advertising effects

Advertising can be broadly defined as any form of paid strategic communication by an identified sponsor that aims at informing and/or persuading receivers about an advertising object (e.g., product, service, brand, organization, or idea), and traditionally it is conveyed via purchased time or space in mass media (Thorson & Rodgers, 2012). In an economic context, advertising is a subcategory and integrated part of all the activities that promote a brand (marketing), next to, e.g., pricing or other forms of marketing communication like personal selling. Advertising has several important societal functions (Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 5–6; Tellis, 2004, pp. 3–5): In markets it is an important factor in facilitating competition between firms because it enables them to communicate efficiently with consumers and thus to compete for their attention and preferences. Moreover, it is a key source of funding for mass media in many media systems, and the advertising industry is an important employer.

In many contemporary societies advertising is omnipresent and its manifold potential consequences offer a fertile ground for research into its intended and unintended, short- and long-term, functional and dysfunctional effects on the individual, collective or organizational level. However, the study of advertising effects is mainly driven by interest in the economic functions that advertising is ought to fulfill. Studies on unintended or dysfunctional advertising effects like materialism, life-dissatisfaction, or eating disorders are rare. Therefore, advertising effects studies mostly investigate either outcomes that are intended by an advertiser, or consumers' mental processes that are supposed to be related to these outcomes as a function of advertising input (see Tellis, 2004, pp. 43–50).

Research typically focuses on one of three characteristics of *advertising input*. First, intensity as the amount of advertising that is targeted to consumers. Second, media as the channel through which advertising is conveyed. Measures of these two input characteristics range from measures of budget (e.g., a firm's advertising expenditures) to measures for the distribution of advertising through single media (e.g., exposure, reach) and measures of advertising contacts in the target population. Third, advertising input is qualified regarding its creative content. Research investigates the effects of a great variety of ad content, for example effects of expert and celebrity endorsers or fear appeals in an advertisement. The *outcomes* that are studied in response to such input are changes in consumer or market behavior. On the individual level, typical outcome measures include consumers' brand choice and purchase intensity. Aggregated measures of outcomes are accounting variables like, e.g., a firm's sales or revenues in response to an advertising input, and market outcome measures that quantify a firm's performance in a market relative to its competitors (e.g., market share). Finally, the term *processes* refers to the mental responses of consumers to an advertising input. Processes are usually classified as cognitive (e.g., thoughts, recall, knowledge), affective (e.g., attitude, image), or conative (behavioral intentions). Correspondingly, the most frequently investigated individual level effects are memory effects, attitudinal effects and behavioral effects with respect to the advertising message and/or the advertising object.

There are two major traditions of the scientific study of advertising effects (Tellis, 2004): the modeling paradigm and the behavioral paradigm. Researchers working in the *modeling tradition* use statistical modeling techniques to relate the intensity of advertising input (mostly ad expenditures and exposures) to behavioral and market outcomes (mostly sales and market share) to determine advertising's effectiveness. For example, the classical Anheuser-Busch field experiments for the Budweiser brand in the 1960s varied the firms' advertising expenditure (i.e., intensity of advertising input) and observed how the brand's sales reacted to these variations (see Tellis, 2004, pp. 74-75). The researchers found that decreasing the level of advertising input did not lead to notable market responses (i.e., decreases in sales) in the short term. By varying expenditures for TV advertising separately, they also varied the second input variable that is commonly used in advertising research: the media through which advertising is distributed. The study showed that only longer suspensions of TV-advertising led to a decline in brand sales.

The primary interest of researchers working in the *behavioral tradition* is in how consumers respond to specific advertising stimuli. They mostly use experimental research designs to relate specific content variables of advertising to individual level responses (i.e., processes) to determine the effects of advertising. For example, a recent study by Weber, Buchmann, & Wirth (2014) explored how *congruence* in the use of unconventional advertising media, i.e., ambient media, affects the attitude towards the advertised brand. In terms of advertising input, congruence is a content characteristic of advertising that is defined as an overlap in the associations evoked by the medium and the advertised brand. In an experiment, participants were exposed either to advertising with congruent ambient media (e.g., a door of a solarium on which the slogan and brand of a travel agency were placed) or to advertising with incongruent ambient media (e.g., the same travel brand whose slogan was placed on a strip of a zebra crossing). The authors compared the attitude towards the advertised brand in the experimental groups and found that it was higher in the groups that were exposed to congruent ambient media. Since attitude is an affective response to a specific advertising stimulus, the study investigated a process variable that is typical for research in the behavioral tradition. In addition, the study gives hints to further processes: It showed that the comparative advantage of congruent ambient media disappeared when participants were highly involved. This indicates that highly involved consumers might be motivated to dissolve any incongruence so that the ambient medium makes sense, and that consequently a mildly incongruent ambient medium can be as efficient as a congruent one in affecting consumers' attitudes.

Modeling approach to advertising effectiveness

The modeling approach is mainly based on *field studies* that use real market data and traditionally investigate relationships between aggregate level variables. Input measures are media spendings, audience or target group reach, and average contact frequency at the level of brands, campaigns and media channels. Typical outcome measures are at the level of markets or market segments, mainly sales, revenues, market shares. Effects can be proven if an input variable's change (increase or decrease) precedes the outcome variable's change in a given timeframe. To examine this kind of causality, traditional studies following the modeling approach usually use aggregate economic data to test so-called econometric models in longitudinal designs. Studies of advertising's effects on economic indicators represent a minority in academic advertising research: In a content analysis of 17 major advertising, marketing, and communication journals, Kim et al. (2014) found economic effects to be focused in about 10 percent of all advertising studies published from 1980 to 2010.

Results from modeling studies are of a high *external validity* for several reasons (Tellis, 2004, pp. 59–60): First, studies are dealing with real brands, products, and advertisements on real markets. Second, they measure real-world consumer behavior, which means that no sampling biases or measurement effects like social desirability or looking-good effects might occur. Third, grand samples are used from commercial market research or in some cases even the whole population is analyzed, e.g. in online advertising when banner contacts are registered and statistically related to online shop visits or shopping activities.

A further advantage compared to experiments is the potential to investigate *time series*. This allows analyzing the so-called advertising carryover, i.e. the question how long the effect of a campaign lasts until it completely vanishes. This mainly applies to products that consumers buy only once every few years (e.g., washing machines, stereos or automobiles). Other time series phenomena are wear-in and wear-out effects. Wear-in measures the time that a new campaign needs to become fully effective; wear-out refers to the loss of a campaign's effectiveness over time, e.g. when the audience starts getting used to and bored by a specific motif or kind of joke.

Nonetheless, modeling studies only allow a *limited level of causality testing* as changes in dependent variables might also be induced by external variables, like market developments or channel irregularities, overriding the effects of the independent variables under analysis. Consequently, cross-lag correlations between a cause at t_0 and an effect measured at t_1 offer no satisfying proof of causality if they are only measured once.

In the past years, advertising research has paid increasing attention to other relevant types of aggregated consumer behavior that became available to researchers: *communicative consumer reactions*. Typical examples are the number of product-brochures ordered or telephone-calls asking for further product or service information. In online and mobile marketing, these and other special types of consumer behavior are called conversions, including, e.g., the number of online shop visits, download of trial licenses, newsletter-subscriptions, and contacts to other marketing or public relations outlets promoted by an initial advertising (e.g., watching a brand's YouTube video). Further consumers' communicative reactions (e.g., Facebook likes, retweets, comments, recommendations) can be registered online and analyzed as outcome variables. Consequently, the dynamic multiplication of easily available market outcome measures in the past years has increased the relevance and spread of modeling studies in advertising effects research beyond the former focus on economic data.

New and easily available data-sources – mainly on the Internet – not only provide a broad variety of aggregate outcome measures, they also allow for the analysis of individual level data in field studies with longitudinal designs. Two examples: Whenever an individual user perceives an advertising banner, clicks on it, then lands at an online shop and finally buys a product there, this sequence of actions is automatically registered and can be analyzed on the individual level. The same applies to Facebook, where each individual fan's communicative action is registered to the minute and can be connected to the stimulating advertising activities.

As the availability of more detailed output measures rose, the portion of field studies scrutinizing the impact of concreter input variables on these output measures also increased. Especially communication studies moved beyond general campaign input data and started to analyze the effects of campaign, media, and copy strategies.

Table 1 provides an overview of all *types of modeling studies* by differentiating the levels of aggregation for input and outcome measures.

Table 1: Classification of input and outcome measures in modeling studies

Level of aggregation	Input		Outcome
high	(1) • advertising budget • advertising weight		(A) • revenue, return-of-investment • advertising elasticity
mid	(2) • campaign strategy • media strategy: advertising frequency and scheduling, selection and combination of media and instruments	X	(B) • sales (aggregate purchase behavior) • aggregate communicative behavior
low	(3) • copy strategy • individual number of contacts to advertisement		(C) • individual communicative and purchase behavior

The highest level of aggregation stands for basic economic variables, often called KPIs (key-performance indicators). On the input-side, classical KPIs are advertising budget and weight, each referring to a specific brand, product, or campaign in a given timeframe. Advertising weight can be represented by the grand total of all potential advertising contacts, which can be calculated by multiplying the number of ads published and each vehicle’s reach. Common outcomes are monetary measures like revenue and return-of-investment. Advertising elasticity is a derived measure indicating how elastic the market reacts to changes in advertising. It measures how effective an increase/decrease of the advertising budget or weight is (elasticity = % change in quantity demanded / % change in advertising).

On the mid-level, operative campaign data are aggregated and analyzed. This refers to the general campaign strategy (e.g. branding versus sales campaign) and the media strategy as input. Typical media strategy parameters are advertising frequency and scheduling tactics (e.g. continuous vs. flighting or pulsing, the selection and combination of media vehicles and advertising instruments (e.g., online banner versus interstitial). As outcome, sales and all other kinds of aggregate consumer behavior can be examined, including the above-mentioned communicative reactions.

On the lowest level, the concrete copy strategy concerning the dimension (e.g. format, spot-length), content and design of each advertisement on the one hand and the individual number of contacts to advertisements on the other can be analyzed as input. As outcome, studies deal with each consumer’s overt communicative and purchase behavior.

It is important to note that all levels of aggregation on the input and output side can be combined. Traditional econometric modeling studies deal with the impact of the advertising budget or weight on effectiveness (type 1xB) or monetary efficiency (type 1xA). Typical question are: What advertising weight is needed to achieve the desired effects? Is there a linear correlation between advertising input and outcome (‘the more the better’) or is there a threshold where an increased weight does not result in an increased output (saturation)? Other studies connect campaign and media strategy characteristics to monetary measures (type 2xA) or to aggregate behavior (type 2xB). Finally, there are field studies investigating the impact of all levels of input measures on individual behavior (mostly type 2xC and 3xC). Prior to the already-mentioned online and social media data, single-source data were used for this kind of studies containing individual-level data of consumers' campaign and copy exposure on one hand, and consumption and communication data on the other (e.g., Lodish et al, 1995). This also permits the investigation of cross-media effects either on an aggregate campaign level (mid input level) or on the individual level focusing on consumers' ad contacts on different media channels (see Assael, 2011).

Behavioral approach to advertising effects

The primary objective of the behavioral approach to the study of advertising effects is to relate distinct qualities of advertising messages to individual consumer responses. Responses of interest are the processing, retention and recollection of advertising information, the formation and change of attitudes toward advertising objects, and behavioral responses (Fennis & Stroebe, 2010). The following paragraphs describe how respective individual level effects are conceptualized in advertising research and they briefly present some mechanisms that are used to explain advertising's impact on these responses (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010 for a detailed treatment of these issues).

Memory effects

Memory effects of advertising are important because many advertising contacts occur in non-purchase contexts (e.g., listening to the radio while doing domestic work) so that an effect of advertising on purchase behavior should somehow be mediated through long-term memory for advertising information (Montgomery & Unnava, 2007).

A basic distinction of memory effects is between effects on explicit and implicit memory (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 82–85). *Explicit memory* is a form of memory that enables the conscious recollection of events and facts. It is usually tested with recognition and (aided and unaided) recall tests of advertising information following advertising exposure (e.g., remembering an advertisement, the advertised product category or brand). *Implicit memory* is a nonconscious form of memory. Implicit memory effects occur when a previous exposure to advertising affects the performance in a subsequent task without that one remembers the advertisement or is aware of its impact on subsequent performance. Typical tasks to test implicit memory are word stem completions and word fragment identifications. In such tests, recipients who have been exposed to advertising are presented with some letters and are asked to identify a word that fits. Implicit memory is shown by completions to words that were content of the advertisement. This effect can occur when the recipient does not explicitly remember the advertising contact and is not aware of the connection between the word identification task and advertising exposure.

It is a common assumption in advertising research that memory is a function of the depth of processing of advertising: the deeper advertising information is processed, the better is explicit memory (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 79–80 for details). A prominent model to represent the different stages of advertising processing is Greenwald & Leavitt's (1984) model of four levels of audience involvement in advertising. The levels differ with respect to the attentional capacity required to process information on each stage. The first stage, *preattentive analysis*, requires no conscious attention, can occur without intention and is likely to result in storage of perceptual and basic semantic information in implicit memory. Processing information on the second level, with *focal attention*, is a prerequisite for advertising to be remembered explicitly. Conscious attention depends on consumer factors (e.g., current desires, attitudes) and features of the advertising message such as vividness, salience, or novelty (Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 51–55). The third level is *comprehension*, i.e. representing the semantic meaning of the message. The deepest level of information processing on which most cognitive capacity is required is *elaborative reasoning* by which the represented information is linked to other knowledge that is stored in memory and what allows for more complex inferences.

One central question with respect to memory effects is how advertising information is retrieved from memory in situations subsequent to exposure (e.g., in purchase situations) and what factors influence *information retrieval*. Research shows that the amount and quality of information that can be retrieved depends on the time that passed between advertising exposure and retrieval situation, on the relative position of a to-be-remembered information in an advertisement or in a set of advertisements (primacy- and recency effects), on repetition and spacing between repeated advertising exposures, on the amount of competitive information in the exposure situation (i.e., advertising clutter), on the presence of appropriate of cues in the retrieval situation (e.g., at the point of purchase), and on the affective state of the individual (see Montgomery & Unnava, 2007 for an overview).

An important process that is based on the activation of memory content is *priming* (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 85–88). Priming is an increase of the accessibility on the mental representation of a word or object (e.g., a brand name, product attributes) that is stored in memory as a result of exposure to this word or object. A consequence of the activation (i.e., priming) of a concept is that, for some time, it can influence the individual's responses in a later unrelated context without any awareness of this influence on the side of the individual (*priming effects*). Priming effects can include evaluative responses such as brand evaluations, or behavioral responses such as purchase decisions. Importantly, priming works with and without awareness of exposure to the priming stimulus. This implies that shallow processing of advertising that is characteristic for incidental advertising exposure, i.e. preattentive analysis, can be sufficient for advertising to have substantial effects.

Attitudinal effects

Advertising's impact on attitudes is investigated because attitudes are believed to be important predictors of behavior, particularly purchase decisions. Research focusses on effects on evaluations of two attitude objects: the advertising object, usually a specific brand (*attitude towards the brand*), and the advertisement (*attitude towards the ad*). There are evaluations that the individual is consciously aware of and that can be tested using self-report measures (*explicit attitudes*), and evaluations that the individual is not aware of and that influence reactions that are not under the individual's conscious control (*implicit attitudes*). Implicit attitudes are assessed by observing such reactions in specifically designed tasks.

Advertising's impact on attitudes can be mediated by a multitude of mechanisms that are at the core of theories that are commonly applied in the behavioral tradition of advertising research. Some of these describe rather cognitive processes, others explain attitudinal effects through affective responses to advertising. A basic cognitive mechanism is that exposure to advertising can increases the cognitive *accessibility* a preexisting attitude toward an advertised object: An advertising message might simply activate the concept of a brand and associated evaluative concepts in memory so that when attitude is tested, the existing attitude can be retrieved more easily than when the brand was not primed by an advertising message. Moreover, an advertising message or its' context might activate concepts beyond the brand, but the brand will be evaluated in the light of the activated concepts (*priming effect*).

Advertising can affect knowledge in form of the beliefs that consumers hold about the advertised object. Classical attitude theory sees such beliefs and their evaluative implications as the building blocks of attitudes (Fishbein, 1963). Thus, advertising can affect attitudes by associating the object with certain attributes and thereby establish or alter beliefs about the advertised object (*belief formation and change*).

Other theories conceptualize advertising's effect on attitudes as the result of message elaboration, i.e. as a function of the net valence of the thoughts that consumers generate in response to the arguments in an advertising message (*systematic processing*). This idea is central in the dual process theories of persuasion that also specify the boundary conditions of this mechanism: high motivation and/or ability to process the advertising message (see Schumann, Kotowski, Ahn, & Haugtvet, 2012 for sources and a review of applications of dual process theories, especially the elaboration likelihood model, in advertising research). Because the favorability of cognitive responses depends on the quality of arguments advertising can influence attitudes by providing strong arguments for the advocated position.

Another way of influence of advertising on attitudes is through conveying information that are part of judgment heuristics (heuristic cues). For example, a product's country of origin can be used by people relying on the country-of-origin heuristic (that is based on country stereotypes) to make attitudinal judgments about an advertised product. Other heuristic cues, e.g. expertise of a spokesperson or the number of arguments, can play a role in the evaluation of the validity of the advocated position in an advertising message and the decision to accept it or not. Dual process theories predict that such heuristic judgments can be a route to persuasion when consumers are not motivated and/or able to think about the message arguments with high effort (*heuristic processing*).

Advertising's impact on attitudes can also be mediated by affective responses. These can range from affective metacognitive experiences accompanying ad processing to discrete emotions that are induced by executional features of an advertising message. An important metacognitive experience is *hedonic fluency*, i.e., the experience of a mildly positive emotion that is associated with a heightened subjective ease of perceiving and processing information. Hedonic fluency can serve as an information to evaluate the processed stimulus, i.e., the ad (Schwarz, 2004) and the attitude towards the ad has a positive effect on attitude towards the brand (MacKenzie, Lutz, & Belch, 1986). Among others, repeated exposure contributes to hedonic fluency because when an advertising message is encountered again, existing memory content, be it implicit or explicit, eases processing. Therefore, hedonic fluency offers one explanation for *mere exposure effects* of advertising.

Both substantive information in an advertising message and its creative execution can elicit emotions in the receiver. Such emotions can influence attitudes in at least two ways. During exposure and/or judgment cognitive concepts can be activated that are congruent with the triggered affective reactions *(affective priming)*. This affects cognitive reactions to the ad, especially thinking about arguments, and thereby attitudes. Another possible mechanism is that affect is used as a basis for judgment (*affect-as-information)*: people infer their attitude towards the advertised brand from their experienced feelings ('how do I feel about it' heuristic) – even if these feelings were induced by executional features of an advertisement (like music) that are irrelevant for the evaluation of the attitude object (misattribution of affect). Affective priming effects are more likely in systematic processing, effects through misattribution of affect in heuristic processing (Forgas, 1995).

Behavioral effects

Conative processes are the most proximate to actual behavior among the measures of mental responses to an advertising input. Research frequently relies on self-report measures to assess *purchase intention, purchase probability, buying interest, attitude toward purchasing* the advertised brand, and *consideration* of a brand for purchasing. In the behavioral tradition, advertising's impact on such measures is often conceptualized as mediated by attitudes (that have been changed or formed through advertising).

According to the MODE-Model (Fazio, 1990), exactly how attitudes affect actual behavior depends on the motivation and opportunity to engage in an effortful decision making process. If this motivation is high (for example when buying expensive durables), the attitude toward the behavior (e.g., attitude toward purchasing a certain brand) will be considered to form a *conscious behavioral intention* (e.g., a purchase intention). The Theory of Planned Behavior (see, e.g., Ajzen, 2005) posits that attitudes don't affect behavior directly but that their impact is mediated by such behavioral intentions which are additionally influenced by subjective norms and the perceived behavioral control with regard to the specific behavior. The potential impact of advertising in this process is that it might affect the beliefs on which attitude, subjective norm, and perceived behavioral control are based.

On the other hand, when motivation and opportunity to make an effortful decision are low (for example when buying everyday consumables), contact with an attitude object can lead *automatically* to attitude consistent behavior (e.g., buying a product that one likes) – without that the consumer consciously considers his attitude, is aware of its influence, or forms an intention. The condition for this is that an attitude towards the object is stored in memory and that this attitude is accessible when the individual encounters the object, i.e., a brand. The potential impact of advertising in this process is that it might affect the attitude and/or general attitude accessibility through repeated contact with the attitude object in non-purchase contexts or that it primes an existing attitude in the purchase situation, e.g., via in store advertising.

Another route of advertising's influence on behavior is through affecting the cognitive accessibility of information that are used by consumers when forming a consideration set in purchase situations (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 95–99). Such information include brand names or contextual information, e.g., typical usage situations for a product. Increased accessibility of such knowledge (for example through repeated exposure to advertising for a brand) increases the likelihood that a brand comes to mind when the consumer deliberately thinks of buying a brand from a certain product category. Moreover, accessibility of information can direct attention and lead to feelings of familiarity when consumers encounter different brands in a purchase situation. This in turn influences which brands will be considered for buying.

Resistance towards advertising

It is well recognized in advertising research that consumers are not naïve receivers of advertising messages that are defenseless against the persuasive attempts of marketers. Consumers frequently try to avoid advertising (for example through zapping TV-ads), and even if they are exposed to it, they oftentimes are not motivated to process the message deeply but follow advertising at best with low attention. Another, more extreme form of resistance is to respond with reactance to the perceived threat to attitudinal freedom that a perceived influence attempt through advertising might cause. Reactance motivates consumers to restore this freedom, for example through increased counterarguing a message's arguments, by disregarding the message or by devaluating the communicator (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010, pp. 184–186).

The advertising literature describes several individual level variables that are likely to moderate the effects of advertising input on cognitive, affective, and behavioral responses. First of all, advertising itself is an attitude object and *attitudes towards advertising* (see, e.g., Tan & Chia, 2007) affect responses to specific advertising stimuli. Research shows that consumers hold attitudes on different levels of concreteness (Attitude towards advertising in general and attitudes towards advertising in different media), and that they differentiate between two objects when evaluating advertising (advertising as a marketing instrument and as a social institution). These attitudes are based on several beliefs, among others beliefs about the informational value of advertising. Negative informational beliefs can be associated with a generalized tendency to disbelief advertising claims, i.e. *ad skepticism* (Obermiller & Spangenberg, 1998), what propels resistance towards advertising. Finally, consumers possess lay knowledge about the aims and tactics of marketers (*persuasion knowledge*) and have developed strategies to cope with persuasive attempts, e.g. by reinterpreting an advertising message on the basis of persuasion knowledge (Friestad & Wright, 1994).

Trends in advertising research

Long-term trends in the academic study of advertising are revealed by the already mentioned content analysis of research articles from 1980 to 2010 by Kim et al. (2014). The analysis shows that advertising effects is the second most frequent topic area of advertising research, with advertising practice (e.g., management issues) being the most frequently studied topic in general. Notably, research that originates from the communication discipline is more likely to address advertising effects than research that is published in pure advertising journals.

The majority of research focuses on *individual level effects*; economic effects, i.e. market outcomes that are the focus in the modeling tradition, are concerned only in a small proportion of research. Interest in individual responses to advertising input dipped between 1980 and 1990 but became dominant since then. Among the individual consumer responses to an advertising input, cognitive effects are examined most frequently, followed by affective effects (such as attitudes) and behavioral effects.

The *media* of interest to advertising researchers changed over the last 30 years. Overall, print is the most studied medium, followed by television. But since 1995, advertising research on the Internet has steadily increased and surpassed television by 2005. However, print advertising in 2010 still was the dominant focus of research. Since 2005, a considerable, yet inconsistent corpus of academic research on mobile advertising and marketing exists, still lacking a broadly accepted definition, conceptualization and framework of the phenomenon (Varnali & Toker, 2010).

The role of *theory* in advertising research increased over the last three decades (Kim et al., 2014). Until mid-1990s, research was mainly driven by empirical results or did not use a theory. With the beginning of the third millennium, theory became more prevalent in advertising research, and by 2005 a clear majority of studies was driven by theory. The main theoretical drivers of advertising research originate from the discipline of psychology: The most frequently used theories and frameworks are *dual-process models*, *information processing theory*, and *congruity theory*. *Involvement*, *interactivity*, and *source credibility* are the three most applied constructs.

Frequently referred concepts from the marketing literature are *brand equity* and *integrated marketing communication*. Advertising specific theoretical approaches that are most frequently used in research are *hierarchy of effects* models, the concept of *attitude toward advertising*, and *advertising effectiveness models*. The most referred contributions from the communication discipline following *interactivity* are the *uses and gratifications approach* and *models of media.* These findings show that *hierarchy of effects* models that conceptualize advertising's effects as a fixed sequence of cognitive, affective, and behavioral effects like the classical AIDA-model (proposing a sequence of attention, interest, desire, and action) are no longer the dominant theoretical tools to understand advertising effects. Sometimes they are used in the modelling tradition of advertising research that observes relationships on the aggregate level to represent assumptions about how advertising works on the individual level (see Tellis, 2004). However, research in the behavioral tradition that explicitly focusses on the individual uses more contemporary psychological approaches to understand advertising's effects (see Fennis & Stroebe, 2010).

The dominant *research orientation* in the study of advertising is empirical and follows a quantitative approach. The empirical quantitative approach has dominated advertising research from the 1980s on but the gap between nonempirical and empirical, as well as between qualitative and quantitative research started to widen in the 1990s. Correspondingly, the *methods* predominantly used in advertising research are quantitative techniques, most prominently laboratory experiments, surveys, and content analyses. A focus on individual level effects that are assessed empirically is also evident in the commonly researched *sampling units*: The most frequently sampled units are adults and students, followed by secondary data sets and advertisements. Among the nonquantitative methods the most commonly applied is the systematic (literature) review.

Among the *implications of research findings* that are typically discussed, practical implications for marketers and advertisers are most commonly addressed by advertising researchers. Far less discussed are theoretical and methodological implications, and consequences for public policy or education are even more seldom addressed. This focus on the practical implications of research results reflects the predominant interest in the economic function of advertising that motivates and justifies research. Therefore it seems that the dominant function of current advertising research is to support the effective and efficient realization of advertising's economic function. Future research on the effects of advertising, especially research that originates in the discipline of communication, could develop alternative and distinct perspectives on advertising effects to be able to contribute knowledge about the manifold consequences that advertising can have on the individual, organizational and societal level.

SEE ALSO: Media Effects: Levels of Analysis; Uses and Gratifications: Basic Concept; Uses and Gratifications: Type of Media; Priming; Dual Process Models of Persuasion; Fear Appeals in Strategic Communication; Attention/Awareness; Interactivity; Modality/Medium Characteristics

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